

Instructional Lesson Paper:

Is this Website Credible?: An Introduction to Lateral Reading

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Introduction: Teaching Scenario

Information literacy is vital in a world where facts are not as influential as they once were. Academics are privileged to learn about information literacy and research fundamentals in their fields of study. Conducting effective and rigorous research involves a large set of skills such as formulating clearly defined questions, choosing appropriate methodologies, database search strategies, data analysis, research ethics, citation evaluation, peer review, and so on. Use of these skills can lead to better literacy habits when interacting with various sources of information online. However, not everyone has access to higher education or formal training in these skill sets. Public libraries have been stepping in to fill this gap and are now teaching literacy concepts that move beyond digital literacy essentials. Digital basics remain important but public librarians can help create a more informed society by expanding their offerings.

This workshop is part of a multi-part series called “Curious Minds” that focuses on helping people learn about the varying degrees of trustworthiness of online sources of information by fostering a sense of wonder. The purpose of this installment is to introduce students to a strategy called lateral reading which is used by fact checkers and information professionals to investigate the credibility of the entity responsible for information found on a website. Lateral reading involves leaving a webpage and opening new browser tabs. These browser tabs are used to find credibility clues about the entity being investigated that do not come from that entity. The clues are then used to better assess how useful online information is. Lateral reading is helpful for making more informed decisions about how to engage with information found online. This tool also has the potential to help individuals use evidence and reasoning rather than absolute statements when choosing information sources.

This workshop will be held in-person. A smaller group size of 10-15 adult learners is ideal for one instruction librarian to facilitate authentic assessment. The duration of the workshop is 45 minutes. This workshop will be marketed via e-newsletters, calendars, social media, bulletin boards, and through other

community organizations. RSVPs will be collected, a finite capacity will apply, and reserved computer labs will be utilized.

Learning Outcomes

To be able to make more informed decisions about the credibility of online information sources, at the end of this workshop, learners will be able to:

- Describe lateral reading in their own words (Exercise 1)
- Demonstrate lateral reading by leaving a sample site to investigate the credibility of the entity responsible for the content (Exercise 2)
- Apply the concepts of lateral reading to information searches online (Exercise 2)

Theory, Framework, or Standards

The format of this workshop is informed by the social constructivist theory of learning which recognizes that “different people can have different reactions and develop different understandings from the same events and circumstances,” “community [is] central,” and “the role of the instructor [is] as a facilitator or guide” (Saunders & Wong, 2020, p.45). The focus of this session is to guide attendees toward a credibility examination strategy. Additionally, the Association of College and Research Libraries’ (ACRL) *Framework for Information Literacy in Higher Education* (2015) applies. All six frames contain concepts that apply to lateral reading but the frames “authority is constructed and contextual,” “information creation as a process,” and “searching as strategic exploration” are particularly relevant. Elements of andragogy were also considered in the construction of this workshop. Since adult learners lean toward self-directed learning (Saunders & Wong, 2020, p.50), this workshop requires internally motivated RSVPs and affords attendees the opportunity to search independently, gathering different evidence for their conclusions, while still achieving the intended learning outcomes.

Lesson Plan Outline

Marketing materials will guide interested parties to register via the library's website, at the reference desk, or by phone. Baseline surveys will be sent to registrants prior to the workshop to evaluate interest and knowledge base. Importantly, the baseline survey will also be used to determine which website examples should be used in the demonstrations to serve registrants more effectively (are most of the registrants interested in news sources, social media sources, medical sources, etc.?). Utilizing the Universal Design for Learning (UDL) framework, the presentation will include opportunities for multiple means of engagement, representation, action, and expression throughout. Students will be encouraged to ask questions, participate in groups activities, and to fill out summative surveys following the workshop. They will also be supplied with shared slide materials, educational videos, infographics, and visual aids. These varied methods and opportunities will reinforce learning despite differing motivations, perceptions, and styles of self-expression.

Part I - Introductions – 5 minutes

- Introduce yourself as the instructor
- Thank students for returning baseline survey
- Briefly overview the topic covered in this workshop (lateral reading is a tool used to help you find your bearings when you aren't sure whether to trust a source)
- **PROVIDE A DISCLAIMER:** Lateral reading investigates the entity responsible for content, not the content itself. It answers "what markers of credibility can I find about who is providing this information?" It makes no claims about the veracity of the information itself. Even the most trustworthy sources have had to print retractions, but we can often avoid being misled by estimating the credibility of a source before using its information
- Encourage questions, thoughts, and reflections throughout

Part II – What is Lateral Reading? – 10 minute “I do” lecture + 5 minute exercise

- Slideshow provides a summary of the research behind lateral reading by Wineberg and McGrew (2019), a definition of lateral reading, an explainer about the benefits of lateral reading versus the downfalls of vertical reading (staying on a website to assess its credibility)
- Walk students through a live demonstration of lateral reading using an example relevant to attendees
 - o For example, if the baseline survey reveals that many registrants are parents interested in sources of medical information, the instructor would introduce learners to a pediatric website that appears to be authoritative but may prove concerning to participants:
 - [American College of Pediatricians](#) (ACPeds)
 - Point out that this website appears professional, organized, official, branded, and easy to navigate
 - Then explain that in this age of information overload, we need to know more about a source before we use their information.
 - Open a new browser tab. Search for “American College of Pediatricians”
 - The first hit will be the entity’s website. Remind learners not to use the entity to measure its own credibility. The second hit is a Wikipedia article. Within the article, highlight data points that speak to this entity’s credibility or lack thereof.
Put data points in context. For example, ACPeds was formed in 2002 and has a membership of approximately 700. Encourage students to become curious about this number. Open a new tab and search “how many pediatricians are there in the United States?”

- Teaching lateral reading is iterative and the instructor will need to deviate from what they've planned based on student input
- ACTIVITY/ASSESSMENT: During demonstration, have students suggest credibility prompts to enter into the search bar, guiding students toward keywords like track record, chronology, or ethos. Use Exercise 1 (see Appendix A) to lead a class discussion for formative assessment.

Part III – Quick Checks – 18 minute “We do” Activity

- Instructor will explain that the class will now shift gears and students will use their computers to work together in small groups to complete the next exercise
- ACTIVITY: Students are introduced to a secondary website that offers the same type of information as the primary website used in the “I do” section above and asked to work together to investigate the credibility of the second entity. Reinforce that students will need to leave this website, in the same manner the instructor did in the previous exercise, and look elsewhere for credibility clues
 - Following the example above, present another pediatric website:
 - [American Academy of Pediatrics](#) (AAP)
 - Ask students to use the worksheet provided to complete Exercise 2 (see Appendix B)
- Remind students that you are available to take questions throughout the activity
- ASSESSMENT: an authentic, direct assessment of student progress will be made by observing student activities and reviewing credibility data during the discussion portion of this activity
 - Following from the example above, students should not be:
 - Reading vertically on the AAP website
 - Clicking on any results published by the AAP
 - Students should be:

- Opening new browser tabs to read laterally
 - Searching for the AAP by name and clicking on results from other entities such as Wikipedia, NIH.gov, JAMA Network to find credibility clues
 - Entering credibility prompts into the search bar such as “American Academy of Pediatrics ethos” or “American Academy of Pediatrics chronology”
 - Discovering that the AAP was formed in 1930 and has 67,000 members.
- DISCUSSION: Review student findings, remind students of the context they’ve gained
 - In the pediatric websites example, we learned that the credibility markers for the AAP and ACPeds differ significantly:
 - The AAP was formed 72 years before ACPeds
 - The AAP has 66,300 more members than ACPeds
 - There are around 60,000 pediatric practitioners in the United States
 - Many other markers may be cited by students

Part IV – Check Yourself – 2 minutes “You do” Guide

- Provide link to guide for future lateral reading (see Appendix C)

Part V – Wrap Up - 5 minutes

- Take any additional questions and thank students for their attendance
- Provide instructor contact information and links to workshop materials
- Explain that you’d like to hear about ways the session was helpful or could be improved
- ASSESSMENT: request that learners return summative survey when received

Part VI - After the Workshop

- Respond via email to any unanswered or follow-up questions from attendees, notate observations
- Send course materials and summative surveys to attendees
- Perform evaluation of summative survey, notated observations, and assessments

Teaching Methods

The teaching techniques being used will include a brief lecture, a carefully narrated demonstration, and an “I do, we do, you do” series of exercises followed by brief discussions regarding the outcomes of student findings. Reading laterally is strategic so it will be important to offer the demonstration section in small chunks, frequently checking in with students as the workshop progresses. Structured activities will be used to monitor student learning.

Assessment Techniques

In addition to the assessments described in the lesson plan above, baseline and summative surveys will be distributed to gather more information for further evaluation.

A baseline survey will be offered. Possible questions may include:

- On a scale of 1-5, how familiar are you with the process of reading laterally to assess the credibility of online sources of information?
- Have you ever felt frustration when considering whether the information you’ve found online is reliable?
- What do you hope to learn about in this workshop?

A summative survey will also be offered. Possible questions may include:

- On a scale of 1-5, how familiar are you with the process of reading laterally to assess the credibility of online sources of information?
- What was the most useful thing you learned in the workshop?
- What additional information could have been covered in the workshop?
- What could the instructor have done better?

Answers to the second summative question may provide further insight into students' progress toward learning outcomes. Assessments will rely on baseline survey, observations gathered during class time, and summative, indirect feedback.

Conclusion: Methods/Techniques Reflection

The approach chosen for this workshop is based on prior research performed by Sam Wineburg, Sarah McGrew, and Mike Caulfield who have produced extensive articles on lateral reading and the benefits of civic reasoning. Their work has been cited in evidence-based policy guides for countering disinformation and recognized by Nobel Peace Prize laureate Maria Ressa. Caulfield and Wineburg co-authored *Verified* (Caulfield & Wineburg, 2023), a book that is advertised as a how-to guide for quick online verification of web-based information sources.

In the research mentioned above, lateral reading was taught using brief conceptual lectures, demonstrations, and discussions as in this workshop. Additionally, the American Library Association (2023) references Caulfield's SIFT method which incorporates lateral reading in the "Investigate the Source" step on its Information Literacy Super Searchers public library initiatives page (para. 8). However, there are certain challenges that have been identified with the use of this method. For example, McGrew's (2024) article on teaching lateral reading discusses the need for students to be able to practice using this method. Practicing lateral reading takes time and the librarian in this exercise is only given 45

minutes. This is mitigated somewhat by allowing students to contact the instructor after the workshop ends but time is also at a premium in public libraries where staff shortages and budget constraints are a reality. McGrew also touches on varying levels of reading comprehension affecting participants' ability to engage with the material (para. 7). This may present difficulties for a public library workshop where everyone is welcome but, in my humble opinion, it would still be worth the effort. Lateral reading workshops like this one, aimed at empowering individuals to assess the credibility of information sources, could be one of several information literacy projects that public libraries can adopt to proactively engage with current literacy research and promote community wellbeing.

References

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Appendices

The exercises below are meant to be scaffolded into the workshop in each of the “I do, We do, You do” sections of instruction.

Appendix A

Exercise 1

1. What does lateral reading mean to you?
2. How is lateral reading useful to you?

Appendix B

Exercise 2

GROUP ACTIVITY:

Instructions: Gather credibility clues by reading laterally to investigate the entity.

1. List 3 search prompts you used.
2. List 3 websites you went to.
3. List 3 credibility clues you found.

DISCUSSION:

1. When investigating the credibility of the entity, what more did you find?

Appendix C

Lateral Reading Guide

[Amanda Clark's Lateral Reading Guide](#)